The first edition of this book was completed during the run up to the 2015 elections in Myanmar and its immediate aftermath. These elections were the first free polls in the country in decades and were widely seen as fair. They were won by Aung San Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD) by a landslide. This despite the fact that a number of seats in the Parliament were reserved for the Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP), the party created by the erstwhile military junta in 2009 to represent their interests in the new civilian system of government.

The Rohingyas have been the enemy within of choice for the succession of dictatorships which have ruled Myanmar since 1962. Arbitrary state violence had been a way of life for them for decades. But the new political dispensation after the 2015 elections allowed the Rohingyas to hope that there might be better times ahead for them. Those hopes and dreams were shared by all the international observers with an interest in the humanitarian record of Myanmar. It was hoped that these elections would change everything.

Yet, even then, most informed observers remained sceptical that the situation would indeed change for the better. For example, one of the things that was airbrushed out of Ms Suu Kyi's international profile, and from the reporting of her pro-democracy movement and party, was that just before the 2015 elections the NLD had removed all Muslims from its candidate lists.

There could have been two explanations for this. One was that the party regarded it as a tactical necessity. The political complexities of Myanmar's slow transition to democracy required even a progressive party to tow the line on most of the issues the military still cared about. Buddhism is one of those those. Until the NLD was actually in power and had had the time to consolidate its position and that of the civilian government against any return to military rule, it would simply have to go along with certain things. Democratic representation of Muslims in parliament and the government would have to wait.

The Rohingyas seem to have pinned their hopes on this possibility. The annual refugee numbers flowing out of Myanmar slowed markedly from the end of 2015 and in the first half of 2016, as the new NLD government took over the reins of power.